



DESTINATION FILE

Melbourne

Naarm — a walkable, transit-rich city on Kulin Country, gateway to penguins and the Great Ocean Road.

COUNTRY

Kulin Nation, VIC

ACCESS

Fly to Melbourne (MEL)

PAX RANKING

#7 of all destinations

STATUS

●Open

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & CHARACTER

Victoria's capital and Australia's second-largest city, on the lands of the Kulin Nation. Melbourne (Naarm) is known for coffee, arts, sport and laneway culture, and serves as the gateway to the Great Ocean Road, Phillip Island and the Yarra Valley. Orange Journeys' #7 destination by pax.

ACCESS

Melbourne Airport (Tullamarine, MEL) is 22km from the city, serving domestic and international flights; Avalon (AVV) is a secondary airport. The city centre is highly walkable with clean, reliable public transport including a free City Circle tram.

BEST SEASON

Year-round destination. March–May (autumn) and September–November (spring) offer mild weather and major events. Summer (Dec–Feb) is warm and festival-heavy. Melbourne is famous for 'four seasons in one day' — clients should pack layers.

GOVERNING BODIES

City of Melbourne

Visit Victoria

Parks Victoria

Public Transport Victoria

Wurundjeri & Bunurong Land Councils

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

National Parks Act 1975 (Vic)

Aboriginal Heritage Act 2006 (Vic)

Marine & Coastal Act 2018

Wildlife Act 1975 (Vic)

02 Kulin Nation & Aboriginal Melbourne

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

Melbourne (Naarm) sits on the lands of the Kulin Nation — principally the Wurundjeri Woi-wurrung and Bunurong/Boon Wurrung peoples, who have maintained connection to this place for more than 2,000 generations.

CULTURAL EXPERIENCES

The Royal Botanic Gardens Aboriginal Heritage Walk is led by Aboriginal guides through a significant Kulin cultural site. The Bunjilaka Aboriginal Cultural Centre at Melbourne Museum and the Koorie Heritage Trust offer deeper cultural context.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Acknowledge the Wurundjeri and Bunurong peoples of the Kulin Nation. Include an Aboriginal-guided experience such as the Royal Botanic Gardens Aboriginal Heritage Walk or a visit to Bunjilaka — Melbourne's Aboriginal culture is often overlooked by visitors focused on coffee and laneways.

03 Sustainability & responsible visiting

A WALKABLE, TRANSIT-RICH CITY

Nearly 90% of journeys within central Melbourne are made on foot, bike or public transport. The City of Melbourne's Transport Strategy 2030 prioritises pedestrians and cyclists. A car-free visit is easy and is the recommended approach for clients.

DAY-TRIP PRESSURE

Melbourne's major drawcards — the Great Ocean Road and Phillip Island — draw heavy day-trip traffic. Encourage clients toward smaller-group operators, overnight stays that spread visitor load, and certified eco-tour operators over large coaches where possible.

SUPPORTING LOCAL

Independent laneway businesses

Aboriginal-owned enterprises

Queen Victoria Market traders

Certified eco-tour operators

Yarra Valley sustainable wineries

BEFORE YOU SELL

Lead with Melbourne's genuine walkability and transit strength. For the Great Ocean Road and Phillip Island, steer clients toward smaller-group and certified operators, and consider overnight options to reduce the long single-day coach trips that dominate these routes.

04 Environment & surrounding nature

CITY & BAY

Melbourne sits on Port Phillip Bay, with parklands, the Yarra River (Birrarung) and Royal Botanic Gardens within the city. The bay supports dolphins, seals and seasonal whale visits, and weedy seadragons in its southern waters.

PHILLIP ISLAND

Little Penguin colony (~40,000)

Australian fur seals

Koalas

Cape Barren geese

Hooded plovers

GREAT OCEAN ROAD

The Twelve Apostles, Otway rainforest and a dramatic coastline. The region holds koalas, glow worms and significant seabird populations. Note the coast is geologically active — the Apostles continue to erode and collapse over time.

PHILLIP ISLAND PENGUIN PARADE

The Little Penguin colony is strictly managed — no flash photography or phones during the Penguin Parade, as light disorients the birds. Brief clients firmly: this rule protects one of Victoria's most important wildlife populations.

05 Getting there & around sustainably

BY AIR & RAIL

Melbourne Airport is 22km from the CBD (rail link and SkyBus available). Within the city, trams, trains and buses use the Myki card, and the free City Circle and CBD tram zone make car-free movement easy.

WALKING & CYCLING

Central Melbourne is flat and highly walkable, with an expanding bike-share and cycleway network. The laneway and arcade culture is best experienced on foot.

DAY TRIPS

The Great Ocean Road and Phillip Island are 1.5–2 hours from the city. Prefer smaller-group tours or rail-plus-shuttle options over large coaches; overnight stays reduce the rushed single-day round trips and spread economic benefit to regional towns.

SUSTAINABLE FRAMING

Melbourne itself is one of Australia's easiest cities to enjoy car-free. The sustainability challenge is the day-trip routes — guide clients toward smaller operators and overnight regional stays rather than long single-day coach loops.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Excellent in the city — Melbourne is one of Australia's most accessible cities, with extensive low-floor trams, accessible trains and flat, walkable streets.

PUBLIC TRANSPORT

Many trams are low-floor and accessible, and major train stations have lifts and ramps. The free City Circle tram is accessible. Check specific tram routes, as older trams remain on some lines.

ATTRACTIONS

The Royal Botanic Gardens, NGV, Melbourne Museum, Federation Square and the riverside precincts are wheelchair accessible. Most major cultural venues have hearing loops and accessible facilities.

DAY TRIPS

Phillip Island's Penguin Parade viewing areas are wheelchair accessible with dedicated viewing. Great Ocean Road lookouts vary — the Twelve Apostles boardwalk is accessible; some coastal steps are not.

PLAN AHEAD

Melbourne city is highly accessible. For day trips, confirm specific operator and venue accessibility — the Twelve Apostles main boardwalk and Phillip Island Penguin Parade both offer accessible viewing.

Sources — City of Melbourne Transport Strategy 2030 · Visit Victoria · Parks Victoria · Phillip Island Nature Parks · Bunjilaka Aboriginal Cultural Centre. Reviewed at least every 12 months.
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